

# On the Status of Zurārah

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## Introduction

Zurārah bin A‘yan was the head of the Shī‘ī community in his time.<sup>1</sup> His narrations are in the thousands,<sup>2</sup> higher than most narrators from Ja‘far al-Ṣādiq and Muḥammad al-Bāqir. However, his biography contains praise from Ja‘far, as well as condemnation. Al-Māmaqānī argues that both have reached the level of mass transmission.<sup>3</sup> This is an exaggeration but the claim is sufficient to establish that Shī‘ī scholars accepted both as authentic. In most cases, Shī‘ī scholars of *rijāl* often appeal to *taqīyyah* in order to make sense out of the conflicting reports in his biography.<sup>4</sup> This brief article dispels the *taqīyyah* narrative and provides a realistic solution in order to solve the contradiction.

“*Taqīyyah*” is a common explanation for the condemnations and damnations found in Shī‘ī sources levelled by the infallible Imams towards their “close” associates. The term *taqīyyah*, or dissimulation, in this scenario, involves the Imam cursing their companions in order to protect them from the authorities and other enemies. This interpretation of the infallible Imam’s criticism carries the obvious risk that any genuine criticism they have for their companions could also be dismissed as *taqīyyah*. Classical and late Shī‘ī scholars that hold this position don’t attempt to provide evidence that a condemned narrator was under any threat. The assumption is that their association with the Imam is sufficient to endanger one’s life. The most famous case in which *taqīyyah* is used as an excuse to defend a narrator is that of Zurārah. However, the condemnations towards Zurārah, when contextualized, display that these were genuine in nature.

Rijāl al-Kashshī,<sup>5</sup> one of the main classical works of Shī‘ī *rijāl*, stands out from others due to its heavy reliance on statements from the Imams about narrators. In contrast, late works like those by al-Ṭūsī and al-Najāshī, mainly offer their personal opinions about the narrators, which highlights the significance of al-Kashshī’s work. The section on Zurārah contains many narrations, both positive and negative, authentic and weak, from the infallible Imams as per Shī‘a standards. The most important of these is one that led to the view that condemnations of Zurārah stem out of *taqīyyah*, a report by his own son, ‘Abdullāh bin Zurārah.<sup>6</sup>

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<sup>1</sup> Al-Najāshī, p. 175.

<sup>2</sup> Al-Khoei, 8/254.

<sup>3</sup> Al-Māmaqānī, 28/113.

<sup>4</sup> Al-Khoei, 8/252; Al-Māmaqānī, 28/115.

<sup>5</sup> Despite not having access to the original, a version that was condensed by al-Ṭūsī, known as *Ikhtiyār Ma‘rifat al-Rijāl*, did survive.

<sup>6</sup> Al-Ṭūsī, 1/380-383. The report contains two paths. All the narrators of the first path are highlighted as reliable by the editor.

Ja‘far al-Šādiq, the sixth Imam, states in the report to ‘Abdullāh, “Greet your father on my behalf, and tell him that I only disparage you in order to protect you,” followed by providing the analogy of the boat that was pierced by al-Khaḍir in Sūrat al-Kahf 71. Al-Khaḍir later explains in the chapter, “As for the ship, it belonged to poor people working on the river, and I wished to mar it, for there was a king behind them who is taking every ship by force.”

The rationale ascribed to the Imam in the narration makes little sense, since the disparagement of Zurārah spread through Muslim communities, as observed in the reports, presumably turning people away from one of the most prolific Shī‘ī narrators. In fact, Ja‘far’s condemnation of Zurārah was also observed by Sunnīs, as we find in a classical Sunnī work of *rijāl*.<sup>7</sup>

However, we are able to derive one beneficial conclusion from the report by ‘Abdullāh bin Zurārah. Even if we reject the attribution of this report to Ja‘far, we can assume that condemnations ascribed to the Imam were in circulation, which led to the formulation of the excuse. With this in mind, the article does not aim to prove that Zurārah was indeed criticized or condemned, for that has already been established, but it intends to investigate and display what led to it.

It should be noted that the narration is considered to be authentic as per Shī‘ī hadth standards, since the narrators are considered to be reliable. One would naturally be skeptical of the fact that the main report being used to exonerate Zurārah, and which allows the dismissal of all criticisms towards him, comes through his very own son.

## Reason for Condemnation

Missing from ‘Abdullāh bin Zurārah’s report is what we find elsewhere in terms of ideological criticisms by the Imam levelled at the prolific narrator. Al-Kashshī collected many reports in Zurārah’s chapter, several of them revolve around the topic of *al-Istiṭā‘a*.

In an authentic report by Ḥanān bin Sadīr, he asked Ja‘far about “the statements of the Jews, Christians, Magians, and the polytheists, are these statements willed by Allāh?” Ja‘far responded, “This is one of those issues raised by the family of A‘yan, which is not from my religion nor the religion of my fathers.”<sup>8</sup>

While the report doesn’t mention Zurārah by name, it does refer to his family, the family of A‘yan, which he is the most prominent member within. The report is about the topic of *al-Istiṭā‘a* (ability), whether human actions are predetermined or not. Zurārah himself had written a book on the subject, called *al-Istiṭā‘a wal-Jabr*, mentioned by early scholars like Ibn Bābawayh.<sup>9</sup> So there is little doubt that Ja‘far’s reaction is directed at Zurārah himself.

The question presented is a polemical one, one that was initially posed by a Qadarite. Qadarites believe that humans have the power to create their own actions independently of God’s will, and, by extension, that God is not the creator of human actions. It’s usually a trick question designed to

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<sup>7</sup> Al-‘Uqaylī, 2/428.

<sup>8</sup> Al-Ṭūsī, 1/405. All narrators are highlighted as reliable by the editor.

<sup>9</sup> Al-Najāshī, p. 175.

get the person to respond in the negative, which would imply their agreement with the Qadarite position.

If one answers in the affirmative, the questioner would counter with, “How can Allāh will for the non-believers to disbelieve? And if He does, then how could He punish them?”

This line of questioning bothered Ja‘far, who simply responded with, “This is one of those issues raised by the family of A‘yan, which is not from my religion nor the religion of my forefathers.”

The conclusion that Zurārah is a Qadarite is also held by Shī‘ī scholar Mīr Dāmād, who explains, “The position that is attributed to Zurārah and his companions, which our master al-Ṣādiq (peace be upon him) said he was free from and that it was ‘neither from his religion nor the religion of his forefathers (peace be upon them),’ is the delegation of the act and its attribution to the servant’s power and will, independent of Allah the Exalted and His will, with any attribution to Him being secondary.”<sup>10</sup>

In a similar report by al-Walīd bin Ṣabīḥ, Zurārah tugs him while in the Prophet’s mosque in Madinah, seeking permission to enter upon Ja‘far. Al-Walīd heads to Ja‘far’s home to inform him. Ja‘far responded, “Don’t allow him, don’t allow him, don’t allow him. Zurārah wants me to be upon his view on predestination at my old age. This is not my religion nor the religion of my forefathers.”<sup>11</sup>

This second report, despite lacking authenticity, supports the previous one, in that Ja‘far’s reaction is due to Zurārah’s position on predestination.

In another report, Hishām bin Ibrāhīm al-Khuttālī quotes al-Reḍā, who pointed out that Zurārah’s position is incorrect. Al-Khuttālī relates that Zurārah’s position opposes the Jabrī position (i.e. fatalism). Al-Khuttālī then says that he follows the view of Ja‘far al-Ṣādiq in terms of *al-Istiṭā‘a*. When Ja‘far was asked about *al-Istiṭā‘a* in Sūrah 3:97: “Pilgrimage to this House is an obligation by Allah upon whoever is able among the people.” He explained that this referred to one’s health and wealth. Al-Reḍā confirmed that Ja‘far’s answer was indeed correct.<sup>12</sup>

It should be noted that al-Reḍā’s critique of Zurārah’s position here occurs a long time after the latter’s death. Hence, the excuse that this was due to *taqīyyah* cannot apply.

The verse mentioned by al-Khuttālī, due to it attributing *al-Istiṭā‘a* to man, was utilized by Qadarites to argue for the view that humans have independent control over creating their actions, and that they are thus not bound by the will of his Creator. However, al-Khuttālī mentions that this was conflicts with Ja‘far, who provided an alternative interpretation of the verse, claiming that “ability” here is actually referring to one’s circumstances in general, in this case, health and wealth.

In a similar report by Ziyād bin Abī al-Ḥalāl, he said to Ja‘far, “Zurārah attributed something to you in regards to *al-Istiṭā‘a*, so we accepted it and believed it, and I’d like to present it to you.” He

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<sup>10</sup> Al-Ṭūsī, 1/394.

<sup>11</sup> Al-Ṭūsī, 1/416. All narrators are highlighted as reliable by the editor with the exception of the teacher of al-Kashshī who was not praised.

<sup>12</sup> Al-Ṭūsī, 1/390. All narrators are highlighted as reliable by the editor.

replied, “Go ahead.” He said: “He claims to have asked you about ‘Pilgrimage to this House is an obligation by Allah upon whoever is able among the people,’ so you said that ‘This refers to whoever has provisions and a mount, then he is able to go to Ḥajj even if he didn’t perform it?’ Then you said, ‘Yes.’”

Ja‘far, replied, “That isn’t how he asked me and that isn’t what I said. **He lied about what I said, by Allāh he lied about me, by Allāh. May Allāh curse Zurārah, may Allah curse Zurārah.**”<sup>13</sup> What he said to me was, ‘One who has provisions and a mount is able to go to Ḥajj,’ so I said, ‘It is mandatory for him [if so],’ So he said, ‘So he is able to?’ I said, ‘No, unless he is permitted [by Allah].’”<sup>14</sup>

This narration is similar to another report in al-Kāfi in which al-Sakūnī says that a Qadarite asked Ja‘far about the verse “Pilgrimage to this House is an obligation by Allāh upon whoever is able among the people,” then said, “Didn’t he give them the ability to do so?” Ja‘far responded: “Woe onto you, ability here means that he has provisions and a mount, it isn’t about physical ability.” The man said, “If the person had provisions and a mount then he is able to perform the Ḥajj?” Ja‘far responded: “Woe onto you, it isn’t as you think, a man can have a lot of wealth, more than the provisions and the mount needed, but still not go to Ḥajj until Allah permits it.”<sup>15</sup>

The second narration, regardless of authenticity, gives us an idea of how Qadarites would use the verse in order to argue for their libertarian view. The response ascribed to the Imam was similar to that used to counter Zurārah, affirming that *al-Istiṭā‘a* occurs through one’s general ability before and during the action if “Allāh permits it.”

In both reports, the Imam alludes to how this stance is sacrilegious, since it entails that the creation has the ability to act within the dominion of the Creator in a way that conflicts with His divine will.

In another authentic report, Muḥammad al-Ḥalabī mentions that Ja‘far said, “This is not my religion nor the religion of my forefathers,” when hearing the position of Zurārah on *al-Istiṭā‘a*.<sup>16</sup>

Other reports that implicate Zurārah of having a heretical position on *al-Istiṭā‘a* includes one by Fuḍayl al-Rassān, in which he states that Zurārah claims to have learned his position from Ja‘far. Ja‘far responds that if hell was the size of a vial, it would fit the family of A‘yan.<sup>17</sup>

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<sup>13</sup> This is not the only narration in which Ja‘far curses Zurārah. Another report in Ikhtiyār Ma‘rifat al-Rijāl 1/396 also contains cursing. All the narrators are highlighted as reliable by the editor.

<sup>14</sup> Al-Ṭūsī, 1/393-394. The narration ends with Ziyād meeting Zurārah, informing him of Ja‘far’s position without letting him know that he was cursed by Ja‘far. Zurārah then boasts that he had attained from Ja‘far what he wanted without him realizing it, in order to affirm his position, while critiquing Ja‘far for not being familiar with philosophical rhetoric. The report does suggest that Zurārah didn’t believe in the infallibility of the Imams. This is in line with another report about him that can also be found on 1/414. Mīr Dāmād states that there is an agreement on the reliability of this path. The editor highlights that each of the narrators was praised as trustworthy.

<sup>15</sup> Al-Kāfi, 4/559.

<sup>16</sup> Al-Ṭūsī, 1/399-400. All narrators are highlighted as reliable by the editor.

<sup>17</sup> Al-Ṭūsī, 1/395. The narration contains multiple unknown transmitters.

In another report, one by ‘Abd al-Raḥmān al-Qaṣīr, Ja‘far tells ‘Abd al-Raḥmān and al-Murādī to admonish Zurārah for his misguided innovation. Zurārah, after being admonished, said, “By Allāh, he had affirmed to me [the position of] *al-Istiṭā‘a* without even realizing.”<sup>18</sup>

In the biography of Muḥammad bin Muslim, we find a companion of the Imam stating that his wife is upon the view of Zurārah and Muḥammad bin Muslim of *al-Istiṭā‘a*. The Imam condemns them, causing the wife to retract her stance.<sup>19</sup>

The three previous reports don’t meet Shī‘ī standards of authenticity and contain some details not found in the previous authentic reports. However, they do corroborate what has already been established about Zurārah’s position, making it likely that some of this information could be authentic. Furthermore, the large number of reports make it evident that the Imam’s condemnation was circulated throughout the community, leading scholars like al-Māmaqānī to consider it mass transmitted.

In summary, the Imam’s condemnation of Zurārah is accepted by Shī‘ī scholars who believe that the Imam only intended to make it seem that he had disassociated from Zurārah. A report that confirms that a condemnation occurred comes via the admission of his son, ‘Abdullāh, who mentions that Ja‘far only did this out of *taqīyyah*. However, the reports that speak of these condemnations that are directed at Zurārah stem from an ideological stance that conflicts with Ja‘far. This confirms that the condemnations were indeed genuine and that the Imam was attempting to turn the Shī‘ī community away from Zurārah due to his heresy.

## Praise for Zurārah and Reconciliation

Without going into much detail, there are several reports included in Ikhtiyār Ma‘rifat al-Rijāl in which Ja‘far mentions Zurārah in a positive light, ranging from authentic to weak. Some of the authentic ones include one that Zurārah narrates himself quoting the Imam saying that his name is written among those that enter paradise.<sup>20</sup> In another, Zurārah is praised for preserving the narrations of al-Bāqir.<sup>21</sup> In yet another, he is one of the most beloved to Ja‘far.<sup>22</sup> With this in mind, how does one reconcile the conflicting narrations?

The possible scenarios are as follows:

- a) Both the praise and condemnation occurred
- b) Neither praise nor condemnation occurred
- c) Only the praise occurred
- d) Only the condemnation occurred

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<sup>18</sup> Al-Ṭūsī, 1/396. The narration contains a couple of unknown transmitters.

<sup>19</sup> Al-Ṭūsī, 1/432. A couple of the narrators are anonymous in status according to the editor.

<sup>20</sup> Al-Ṭūsī, 1/371.

<sup>21</sup> Al-Ṭūsī, 1/377.

<sup>22</sup> Al-Ṭūsī, 1/375.

If we assume scenario (a), then this would likely be due to Ja‘far contradicting himself. Perhaps he initially had a positive opinion of Zurārah before coming across his heretical ideology. It would be hard to assume that the order should be reversed since nothing indicates that Zurārah repented.

The authenticity of both sets of reports would also be in line with the *taqīyyah* hypothesis, however, this is not likely since the condemnations are frequently linked to Zurārah’s ideology, which clearly conflicted with the Imam’s teachings. Hence, a clear motive for the condemnation is established, one that is more convincing and outweighs the evidence that Zurārah was being protected, especially since Zurārah’s misguidance on the topic of *al-Istiṭā‘a* isn’t a trivial matter.

If we assume that there were no real statements about Zurārah, as per scenario (b), then we would have to explain the existence of the tens of conflicting reports surrounding him. It is far likelier that one set of reports was manufactured to combat the other.

Scenario (c) was previously addressed since the narration of ‘Abdullāh bin Zurārah defending his father contains an admission that the condemnation did occur.

And this leaves us with scenario (d), which is that the only truly authentic reports are those in which Zurārah is condemned. The only issue with this scenario is that it conflicts with Shī‘ī *rijālī* standards that include “authentic” strands of transmission in praise of Zurārah. However, like much of the Shī‘ī corpus, the number of contradictions seem to stem from a large number of seemingly “authentic” reports, which led classical scholars to assume that the Imam is practicing *taqīyyah*, even when there is no reason for him to do so. If *rijālī* standards were stricter, more narrations would be filtered out, leaving a smaller number of attributions that would better reflect reality. In this case, what would remain are the authentic reports condemning Zurārah for his position on *al-Istiṭā‘a*.

## Implications and Recommendations

The disparaging remarks made by Ja‘far represent the earliest known criticisms of Zurārah. They come from a scholar who is his contemporary, one admired by both Sunnīs and Shī‘īs. Despite this not having much implications on Sunnī *ḥadīth* due to the lack of Zurārah’s reports therein, it would have an effect on the Shī‘ī corpus that contains thousands of reports by Zurārah.

Further research into the biographies of other Shī‘ī transmitters who received conflicting praise and condemnations from the Imams is warranted, to determine if similar conclusions can be drawn.

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